

THE HILL

A Southern gothic family series about blood, land, silence, and what a place remembers.

Overview

The Hill is a dramatic television series built around the Horner family, Mulberry Township, and the buried violence that shaped a rural Arkansas community.

The series begins before the known historical rupture and moves toward it slowly — through family tension, land pressure, local politics, rumor, fear, and the quiet machinery of a place preparing to turn on itself.

This is not a war story told from a battlefield.

It is a family story told from the kitchen table, the road, the churchyard, the field, the ridge, and the grave.

The violence matters.

But the silence before it matters more.

Series Logline

In Civil War-era rural Arkansas, a divided family tries to hold itself together as local loyalties, old grudges, and hidden violence close in around them — until one ordinary meal becomes the last moment before everything changes.

Pilot Episode

Episode 1 — “Mulberry Township”

The pilot introduces the Horner family before the attack.

It follows one long day as pressure builds across the township: neighbors watching neighbors, old political divisions hardening, family members sensing danger without fully naming it, and the ordinary rhythms of farm life becoming charged with dread.

The episode does **not** end with the attack itself.

It ends with the family gathered for a chicken dinner — the last ordinary meal before the rupture.

Core Creative Principle

Dread, not spectacle.

The series does not rush to violence.

It lets the audience feel the pressure before the break.

The horror is not only what happens.

The horror is how normal everything still looks right before it happens.

Tone

The tone of **The Hill** is:

- Southern gothic
- Historical drama
- Family tragedy
- Slow-burn dread
- Grounded, unsentimental, and intimate
- More atmosphere than exposition
- More restraint than spectacle

Think:

- family table instead of battlefield
 - silence instead of speeches
 - land as witness
 - history as pressure
 - violence as consequence, not entertainment
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Themes

The Hill explores:

- inherited violence
 - family loyalty under pressure
 - land memory
 - community complicity
 - class, power, and survival
 - the collapse of ordinary life
 - what people know but refuse to say
 - how history hides in local names, cemeteries, roads, and stories
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Main Setting

Mulberry Township, Arkansas

The story is rooted in rural Arkansas hill country.

The land is not background.
It is an active force in the series.

Fields, ridges, caves, cemeteries, creeks, tree lines, and homesteads all carry narrative weight.

The Hill is not just where the family lives.
It is what watches them.

Historical Foundation

The series is inspired by the real Horner–Hill family history and the violence surrounding Spencer Horner and William Riley Horner in 1864.

Known historical anchors include:

- Spencer Horner
- William Riley Horner
- the Horner homestead
- the cave / overhang survival story
- Mulberry Township
- the postwar family consequences
- the later Horner–Hill connection through marriage
- the unresolved memory of violence in Johnson County, Arkansas

This project uses history as foundation, not prison.

The series is dramatized, but the emotional architecture is built from real family memory, local geography, and documented historical trauma.

Episode Structure

The series is designed as a prestige limited or ongoing historical drama.

Episode 1 — “Mulberry Township”

The last normal day.

Episode 2 — Working Concept

The aftermath begins.

The attack has happened, but the story follows survival, hiding, discovery, fear, and the first fracture of memory.

Series Direction

Future episodes may follow:

- the immediate aftermath of the Horner violence
 - the community response
 - William Riley's survival and death
 - refugee movement and family dispersal
 - postwar silence
 - land records and buried truth
 - the later Horner–Hill marriage
 - modern recovery of the story
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Repository Purpose

This repository is the working development archive for **The Hill** series.

It may include:

- pilot drafts
- episode outlines
- act breakdowns
- character notes
- setting notes
- historical research
- family timeline materials
- dialogue fragments
- visual references
- production concepts
- pitch materials

This repo is not just storage.

It is the build room.

Suggested Repository Structure

```
the-hill-series/  
|  
├─ README.md  
|  
├─ 00-series-bible/  
|   ├── series-overview.md  
|   ├── themes.md  
|   ├── tone-and-style.md  
|   ├── historical-foundation.md  
|   └─ timeline.md  
|  
├─ 01-pilot/  
|   ├── episode-01-mulberry-township.md  
|   ├── act-01.md  
|   ├── act-02.md  
|   ├── act-03.md  
|   └─ act-04-the-chicken-dinner.md  
|  
├─ 02-episodes/  
|   ├── episode-02-outline.md  
|   ├── episode-03-outline.md  
|   └─ season-arc.md  
|  
├─ 03-characters/  
|   ├── spencer-horner.md  
|   ├── william-riley-horner.md  
|   ├── family-map.md  
|   └─ township-figures.md  
|  
├─ 04-setting/  
|   ├── mulberry-township.md  
|   ├── horner-homestead.md  
|   ├── cave-overhang.md  
|   ├── roads-and-ridges.md  
|   └─ cemeteries.md  
|  
├─ 05-research/  
|   ├── historical-notes.md  
|   ├── land-records.md  
|   ├── family-timeline.md  
|   └─ source-log.md  
|  
└─ 06-visuals/
```

```
| | moodboard-notes.md
| | episode-02-photo-concepts.md
| | location-reference.md
|
└─ 07-pitch/
    ├── logline.md
    ├── one-page.md
    ├── pitch-deck-notes.md
    └── treatment.md
```

Current Status

The pilot is being developed act by act.

Current known structure:

- **Act One:** Establishes the family, place, and first pressure.
- **Act Two:** Deepens township tension and family unease.
- **Act Three:** Builds dread without announcing dread.
- **Act Four:** “The Chicken Dinner” — the final ordinary family meal before the attack.

The pilot’s core ending is locked:

The family sits down to eat.

The audience knows something is coming.

The characters do not fully know yet.

Cut before violence.

Writing Rule

Do not over-explain.

Let the land, behavior, silence, and small domestic details carry the dread.

A glance can matter more than a speech.

A dog not barking can matter more than a gunshot.

A quiet dinner can be more frightening than the attack itself.

Project Statement

The Hill exists because family history does not stay buried.

It waits.

In names.

In land.

In courthouse records.

In cemeteries.

In stories people half-tell.

In roads people still drive without knowing what happened there.

This series is an attempt to give that silence a shape.

Not to clean it up.

Not to make heroes and villains simple.

But to stand in the middle of it and tell the truth with weight.

Author / Creator

Created by **Bret Lingar**

Based on the Horner–Hill family history, Mulberry Township research, and the long recovery of a buried Arkansas story.

Working Taglines

The land remembers what the family tried to survive.

Before the violence, there was dinner.

Every family has a place where the story turns.

The Hill was never quiet. It was waiting.